

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Boil-water advisory

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use bottled water or bring clear tap water to a rolling boil for 1 minute, then cool it; above 6,500 feet, boil for 3 minutes. Use approved water for drinking, cooking and brushing teeth. Follow the exact local notice. Boiling does not remove chemical contamination.

Do now.

☐**Confirm the notice**

01

Check that it is a boil-water advisory, rather than do-not-drink or do-not-use.

☐**Boil and cool**

02

Use the local authority instructions; allow water to cool safely before use.

☐**Prevent accidental use**

03

Avoid connected refrigerator water and ice; use safe water for food, formula and pets.

☐**Follow the all-clear**

04

Resume normal use only after official clearance and any flushing instructions.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If fuel or electricity is unavailable, use sealed drinking water first. A treatment tablet is an option only for microbial risk and only when its label covers the conditions. If you cannot establish whether chemicals are involved, change the water source rather than experimenting.

Watch for.

A household pitcher filter does not replace boiling during this advisory.

People & practical needs.

Keep one clearly marked clean-water supply for drinking, brushing teeth, food and medicine. Ask the care team about medical devices requiring special water. Powdered formula is not sterile; feeding plans need extra care for young or vulnerable infants.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Keep bottled water and a safe means of boiling available. If boiling is impractical, use the alternative named by officials.

Check the next usable option

Keep bottled water and a safe means of boiling available. If boiling is impractical, use the alternative named by officials.

When the first option is unavailable

If fuel or electricity is unavailable, use sealed drinking water first. A treatment tablet is an option only for microbial risk and only when its label covers the conditions. If you cannot establish whether chemicals are involved, change the water source rather than experimenting.

Questions in the field.

Does my filter remove the need to boil?

Do not assume it does. Household filters may not remove all germs, and some do not address the contaminant involved. Follow the actual advisory and the linked CDC instructions; use bottled water when boiling cannot be done safely.

How do I avoid recontamination?

Cool treated water safely and store in a clean, covered food-grade container. Keep dirty utensils and untreated water away from it. Mark the container and use a clean method to pour or dispense.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Boil-water advisory · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/drinking-water-advisories-an-overview.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/boil-water-advisory/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.